stating that it was a good beginning.[200] Deng, on his part, commented to journalists from India, “How can we not be friends?”[201]

Vietnam Once More

But then, even before Vajpayee left the country, came China’s invasion of Vietnam. Brzezinski had seen the earlier Vietnamese invasion of Cambodia as having taken place under the Soviet umbrella, much like the Indian action during the 1971 Bangladesh crisis.[202] A Carter administration interagency group had expected Beijing to take “stern action” against Hanoi to “avoid ‘paper tiger syndrome,’” but not until after Deng had visited the US. Washington did not see Sino-Soviet escalation in Indochina to be in US interests—it would adversely affect China, and complicate East-West relations.[203] Thus, while the US cooperated with China at the UN on the Vietnam-Cambodia issue, Vance urged Beijing not to do anything militarily.[204]

When they met, Carter had told Deng that “the invasion of Vietnam would be very serious destabilizing action.” The Chinese leader had responded that he understood the US wanted Chinese restraint, but “we intend a limited action. Our troops will quickly withdraw.” He pointed to what China had done against India in 1962 as an example.[205] A concerned Carter had then spoken privately to Deng and emphasized that any “punitive action” would be a “serious mistake” and the US “could not support such action.” He had “strongly” urged Deng “not to approve it” and instead to go through the UN.[206]

Delhi had been aware when Vajpayee’s trip was being planned that a Chinese invasion of Vietnam was possible—if not likely. Therefore, the Indian ambassador in Beijing had expressed the hope to his Chinese interlocutors that there would be no “incident” during the trip.[207] During the visit, Deng did hint that something was in the offing vis-à-vis Vietnam, telling Indian journalists that China wished for peace, but “What can we do if people deny us this wish, and if sometimes we may have to do something we do not want to do?”[208] But, subsequently, India was particularly irked that the invasion took place during Vajpayee’s visit, that there was no official hint of it, and that Beijing publicly compared its action against Vietnam to the one against India in 1962. The Chinese invasion, as a